

Affective Polarization and Free Speech Among College Students at UNC Charlotte

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Abstract

This study examines affective polarization and its relationship to campus free speech attitudes using survey data from 779 undergraduates at UNC Charlotte collected during the Fall 2025 semester. Affective polarization is operationalized through three theoretically distinct components: othering, moralizing, and social aversion (Campos and Federico, 2021). Then, data analyses were conducted in four consecutive stages: Cronbach's alpha for scale reliability, independent-samples t-tests with Cohen's d effect sizes, exploratory dimensionality reduction via PCA and UMAP, and Ordinary Least Squares (OLS) regression with interaction terms. Findings reveal a pronounced partisan asymmetry. Democrats exhibit significantly higher affective polarization toward Republicans than Republicans exhibit toward Democrats ($d = 0.78$, $p < .001$) with the gap overwhelmingly driven by social aversion ($d = .92$). Republicans express significantly greater support for restricting campus speech for both faculty and students ($d = 0.69$). OLS regression establishes that polarization components do not significantly predict speech restriction attitudes once the party is controlled, and no interaction terms reach

significance. These findings suggest that partisan social distance and campus speech norms operate as largely independent dimensions of political psychology in this population.

Keywords: affective polarization, free speech, college students, partisan asymmetry, social aversion, campus climate

Introduction

American political polarization has intensified dramatically over the past two decades, and universities have emerged as a focal point for debates about its consequences (Heltzel & Laurin, 2020). Current academic literature focuses heavily on partisan sorting and ideological divergence (Mason, 2018; Levendusky, 2009). Yet, comparatively less work examines how affective polarization manifests among young adults, or whether polarization shapes attitudes toward fundamental democratic norms such as free speech.

The political context surrounding data collection is itself relevant. The Fall 2025 semester coincided with the early months of the second Trump administration, a period marked by heightened partisan tension, executive-branch confrontation with universities over diversity and equity policies, and renewed national debate over campus speech norms. These contextual pressures may have amplified the polarization dynamics observed in this sample.

Affective polarization, broadly defined as general negative emotional feelings toward political out-parties that are distinct from policy disagreement, has emerged as a central concern in democratic theory (Iyengar et al., 2019; Finkel et al., 2020). Research consistently finds that Americans increasingly view the opposing party with distrust, contempt, and even disgust, regardless of their positions on specific issues (Orr & Huber, 2020). A defining feature of this literature is a persistent asymmetry between parties. Democrats have exhibited higher out-party hostility than Republicans across multiple studies and methodologies (Orr & Huber, 2020; Finkel

et al., 2020; Nair et al., 2025). This study examines whether that asymmetry replicates in a single-institution campus context and tests whether individual-level polarization predicts support for restricting campus speech.

College campuses have become particularly prominent in this conversation. High-profile incidents involving campus speakers, faculty speech controversies, and debates over academic freedom have drawn sustained public attention to whether students and faculty uphold norms of open inquiry consistent with academic values (Stevens, 2021). Moreover, most existing studies treat free speech attitudes as a single, undifferentiated construct. A key aspect of data collection and analysis is distinguishing between faculty and student speech contexts and disaggregating the components of polarization that might drive polarization attitudes.

This study addresses these concepts using data from 779 undergraduates at UNC Charlotte, a large public university in the Southeast. Affective polarization is operationalized through three theoretically distinct components, othering, moralizing, and aversion, following Campos and Federico's (2021) framework. Support for free speech is assessed through separate batteries for faculty and student speech, allowing the study to test whether different components of polarization differentially predict restriction attitudes across these two domains. OLS regression with interaction terms is then used to isolate the contribution of polarization above and beyond partisan identity, and to test for moderation by party.

The central finding is a polarization-speech paradox: Democrats, the more affectively polarized group, are simultaneously more supportive of free speech on campus. Furthermore, at the individual level, the relationship between polarization and speech attitudes is party-dependent: among Democrats, no component of polarization predicts speech restriction attitudes. However, among Republicans, social aversion is a significant positive predictor of

support for restrictions. The paradox therefore applies most cleanly to Democrats, for whom high emotional hostility toward Republicans coexists with stronger aggregate support for free speech and no within-group polarization–restriction link.

Literature Review

Affective Polarization: Definitions and Dimensions

Scholars draw an important distinction between ideological polarization (divergence in policy positions), and affective polarization (the emotional evaluations of the opposing party independent of issue distance) (Iyengar & Westwood, 2015). Feeling thermometer measures, social distance factors, and trait attribution tasks all converge on a consistent finding: Americans increasingly view political opponents with hostility, even when policy differences are held constant (Ahler & Sood, 2018). Iyengar et al. (2019) document in their comprehensive review that affective polarization in the United States has reached historically elevated levels, driven largely by partisan sorting across racial, religious, and ideological dimensions. Although conducted in 2019, Iyengar et al. suggest that these polarization levels will continue to rise unless combative action is taken. In order to quantify these theories, and serving as the basis of this analysis, a previous framework was taken.

Campos and Federico (2021) propose a three-component framework that disaggregates this hostility into conceptually distinct mechanisms. Othering refers to perceiving out-party members as fundamentally alien, not merely politically different but categorically unlike oneself. Moralizing captures the fusion of partisan identity with moral identity, viewing one's own party as the morally correct side and its opponents as morally deficient. Aversion measures behavioral disposition toward social distance, such as the unwillingness to maintain friendships, family relationships, or social ties with out-party members. These three components share conceptual

space but may respond differently to contextual factors, including institutional environment and education level (Finkel et al., 2020). This is especially where the public, Southeastern, and diverse socioeconomic setting of UNC Charlotte takes importance. The Affective Polarization Scale developed by Rapp et al. (2024) independently validates this multi-component structure, confirming that the three subdimensions are positively correlated but not redundant, and that each independently predicts outcomes associated with polarization.

The choice to measure all three components separately, rather than relying solely on feeling thermometer measures, reflects an important methodological consideration raised by Druckman and Levendusky (2019). Their research finds that thermometer-based measures may conflate dislike of out-party leaders with dislike of ordinary partisans, while social distance items tap a meaningfully distinct behavioral dimension. By operationalizing all three components, this study can assess which facet of polarization does the most work in differentiating partisan groups and in predicting speech attitudes.

Social Identity Theory as a Foundation

The partisan dynamics documented in affective polarization research are grounded in Social Identity Theory (Tajfel & Turner, 1979; Turner et al., 1987), which explains why group-based hostility arises and intensifies even without genuine resource conflict. Social Identity Theory holds that individuals derive part of their self-concept from membership in social groups, which motivates in-group favoritism and out-group derogation as a consequence of categorization and the need to maintain a positive social identity. When partisan identity functions as a social identity, negative evaluations of the out-party become psychologically motivated by group-protection processes rather than by reasoned policy disagreement. This dynamic parallels what evolutionary and anthropological scholars describe as tribalism. This is

the tendency to organize social life around bounded in-groups, enforce strong loyalty norms within them, and treat out-group members with suspicion or hostility (Greene, 2013; Haidt, 2012). While Social Identity Theory locates these processes in identity-based categorization, tribalism frameworks emphasize their deep behavioral and motivational roots, suggesting that partisan polarization draws on psychological tendencies that predate modern political institutions.

Mason (2018) applies this framework to contemporary American polarization, arguing that the process of social sorting, the alignment of race, religion, education, and ideology along partisan lines, has made partisan identity simultaneously more encompassing and more psychologically threatening to challenge. University campuses represent an environment of particularly strong social sorting, where partisan identity correlates tightly with race, educational level, and ideological self-identification (Mason, 2018; Levendusky, 2009). Additionally, university is a unique time, often a space where a young person has independence from parents for the first time. The university setting, especially in socioeconomic diverse ones, offers a place where varying political groups, races, identities, and classes are required to intertwine/interact in general education classes or shared common spaces. These factors suggest that affective polarization dynamics may be at least as pronounced on campus as in national adult samples, making universities a theoretically important and understudied site for this research.

Partisan Asymmetry in Affective Polarization

A consistent finding in the national literature is that Democrats and Republicans do not polarize symmetrically. Orr and Huber (2020) document that Democrats express higher out-party hostility across multiple large datasets and diverse operationalizations, and that this gap has widened over time. Finkel et al. (2020) similarly report that affective polarization accelerated

more sharply among Democrats in recent election cycles. Explanations for this asymmetry range from compositional differences in party coalitions to elite rhetoric to the structure of partisan social networks.

The most direct experimental evidence for this asymmetry comes from Nair et al. (2025), who conducted five preregistered studies and two social media field experiments with a combined sample exceeding 12,000 participants. These studies found that Democrats dislike Republicans more across multiple behavioral measures, including social media blocking, likability ratings, and hiring decisions. Critically, these studies trace this asymmetry to Democrats' moralized belief that Republicans pose harm to racial and ethnic minority groups. This mechanism connects directly to the moralizing and aversion dimensions of the Campos-Federico framework and helps explain why Democrats' social distancing from Republicans is grounded in moral conviction rather than mere personal preference.

Republican Underreporting and Measurement Considerations

An important interpretive question in asymmetric polarization research is whether Republicans' lower reported polarization reflects genuine attitudinal differences or is partly an artifact of differential measurement dynamics, including social desirability bias and expressive responding. Bullock et al. (2015) and Prior et al. (2015) document that partisan respondents frequently use survey answers to signal group loyalty rather than to report true beliefs. Rapp et al. (2024) find that among high-scoring respondents on their affective polarization composite, Republicans' polarization more strongly predicts anti-democratic attitudes and support for political violence, suggesting that high-polarization Republicans may express hostility through behavioral channels that standard self-report measures, such as this survey, fail to capture.

Countervailing evidence suggests the asymmetry is not simply a measurement artifact. Multiple independent operationalizations using feeling thermometers, trait ratings, social distance items, and behavioral experiments consistently show Democrats reporting higher out-party hostility (Iyengar & Westwood, 2015; Orr & Huber, 2020; Nair et al., 2025). Kekkonen and Reunanen (2022) further document that social desirability constraints around partisan hostility are weaker in political domains, because partisans openly express disdain for the other side. The preponderance of evidence therefore supports treating the partisan asymmetry as substantively real, while acknowledging that the behavioral significance of Republican polarization may be understated by self-report measures alone.

Political Tolerance and Free Speech Norms

Research on political tolerance provides the theoretical basis for examining partisan differences in campus speech attitudes. Sullivan, Piereson, and Marcus (1982) established in their foundational study that most Americans hold strong abstract commitments to free speech as a democratic principle, but are substantially less tolerant when the speech in question comes from groups they find threatening or morally objectionable. This divergence between abstract and applied tolerance, what they call the tolerance gap, is critical for interpreting survey-based campus speech measures. Abstract free speech questions may yield very different responses than items that make the speaker's viewpoint or identity concrete.

Gibson (1992) extends this framework, finding that political tolerance correlates with political sophistication, commitment to procedural democratic norms, and the perceived threat level associated with the group in question. Chong (2006) adds nuance by showing that on abstract free speech questions, ideological conservatives are modestly more likely to endorse speech rights as a matter of principle. However, this pattern attenuates substantially when the

speech being evaluated is associated with left-coded or identity-based content. At large public universities, such as UNC Charlotte, Republicans constitute a numerical minority (Langbert, 2018), which threat-based theories predict would increase their support for administrative restrictions on speech they perceive as hostile to their viewpoints.

Research Questions and Hypotheses

This study advances three primary research questions:

1. Do Democrats and Republicans at UNC Charlotte differ significantly in affective polarization, replicating the asymmetric pattern documented in national adult samples?
2. Which component of affective polarization, othering, moralizing, or social aversion, most strongly differentiates Democrats from Republicans?
3. Does affective polarization predict support for restricting campus speech, and do these relationships differ by component and by party?

From these questions, three hypotheses are derived, each grounded in prior empirical findings:

H1: Democrats in the sample will exhibit stronger affective polarization than Republicans.

This prediction follows from a convergent body of national survey research. Iyengar et al. (2019) document that out-party hostility increased substantially faster among Democrats than Republicans across the 2000s and 2010s. Orr and Huber (2020) replicate this asymmetry across multiple large datasets and show it holds across diverse operationalizations. Finkel et al. (2020) similarly report that the partisan hostility gap widened more sharply on the Democratic side in recent election cycles. Nair et al. (2025) confirm this pattern across five preregistered experiments with over 12,000 participants and trace it to Democrats' moralized belief that Republicans endanger racial and ethnic minority groups, a mechanism that generates sustained,

cross-situational hostility. Because this asymmetry appears robustly across methodologically diverse designs in national samples, this study expects it to replicate in a college context. Mason (2018) suggests that the strong social sorting typical of university environments may amplify rather than dampen affective polarization, making a college sample a theoretically appropriate site for replication.

H2: Social aversion will show the largest partisan gap among the three components of affective polarization.

This prediction rests on two distinct lines of evidence. Iyengar and Westwood (2015) demonstrate experimentally that partisan discrimination is substantially stronger when it takes a behavioral and social form, such as preference in hiring decisions or romantic partner selection, compared to abstract evaluative judgments. They argue that social identity processes trigger automatic in-group favoritism most powerfully in contexts that directly invoke group membership. Druckman and Levendusky (2019) additionally find that social distance survey items tap a distinct and more robust dimension of partisan animosity than standard thermometer measures. The social aversion subscale in this study directly measures students' willingness to befriend, spend time with, or maintain close relationships with out-party members, it operationalizes precisely the behavioral dimension that prior research identifies as most extreme. Social aversion is therefore expected to show a larger partisan gap than either moral identity or othering, both of which tap more abstract evaluative judgments.

H3: Republicans in the sample will express more support for free speech restrictions than Democrats.

H3 is derived from the political tolerance tradition rather than from the principled conservatism literature. Sullivan, Piereson, and Marcus (1982) demonstrate that abstract free speech commitments do not extend to groups perceived as threatening, and that institutionally marginal groups are more likely to endorse restrictions on hostile speech. At large public universities, Republicans constitute a numerical minority (Langbert, 2018). Threat-based accounts therefore predict that Republican students, experiencing campus environments as ideologically hostile, will express more support for administrative speech enforcement. The competing principled conservatism account (Chong, 2006; Gibson, 1992) predicts the opposite. These accounts generate directional predictions for a campus sample rather than a national one, and because the political context of Fall 2025 may have reinforced Republicans' perception of campus speech as institutionally threatening, this study derives H3 from the threat-based framework while acknowledging the genuine theoretical competition.

Methods

Data and Sample

Data come from the UNC Charlotte POLS Lab Student Omnibus Survey, administered in Fall 2025 to students enrolled in general-education courses. The sampling frame was designed to capture a cross-section of the undergraduate population rather than targeting political science majors, providing broader representativeness of campus political views. After removing incomplete responses and metadata rows, the analytic sample consists of 779 respondents. The survey was administered via Qualtrics. Standard data cleaning included removal of respondents completing the survey in under three minutes, deduplication by response ID, and listwise deletion for any respondent missing more than 50 percent of items on a given subscale.

Table 1*Party Identification Distribution*

Group	N	%
Democrats (including leaners)	437	56.1
Republicans (including leaners)	130	16.7
True Independents	84	10.8
Other / Missing	128	16.4
Total	779	100

Note. Leaners are respondents who initially identified as Independent but expressed a directional lean on a follow-up item.

Democrats outnumber Republicans 3.4:1, consistent with the partisan composition of large public universities. Partisan sorting in this sample is very high: a Spearman correlation between party identification and ideological self-placement yields $r = 0.799$ ($p < .001$), indicating near-perfect alignment between identity and ideology in this population. This imbalance is addressed throughout the analyses by prioritizing effect sizes over significance tests, since the large Democratic N inflates statistical power and can produce significant results for substantively trivial effects.

Statistical Approach

All analyses were conducted in Python 3.11 using scientific computing libraries. Pandas and numpy for data management and numerical computation, scipy and statsmodels for

statistical testing and regression modeling, scikit-learn for dimensionality reduction, and matplotlib/seaborn for visualization. The analytic strategy proceeded in four stages, each chosen to address a specific inferential goal.

Stage 1: Scale Reliability. Before computing composite indices, the internal consistency of each multi-item subscale was assessed using Cronbach's alpha (Nunnally, 1978). Internal consistency quantifies the degree to which items within a scale correlate with one another, providing evidence that they measure a common underlying construct. Alpha values below 0.70 indicate insufficient coherence for compositing (Nunnally, 1978). Cronbach's alpha was chosen over alternatives such as McDonald's omega because its assumptions are appropriate for the approximately parallel item structures in this battery. Additionally, it is the standard approach in survey-based political science research prior to index construction (Iyengar & Westwood, 2015; Rapp et al., 2024).

Stage 2: Between-Group Comparisons. To test H1, H2, and H3, Democrats and Republicans were compared on each composite index using independent-samples t-tests, the appropriate inferential method for comparing two independent groups on a continuous outcome (Field, 2013). All tests are two-tailed. Cohen's d is reported as the primary measure of effect magnitude because, unlike p-values, it is independent of sample size and directly communicates practical significance. Effect sizes are interpreted using Cohen's (1988) benchmarks: $d = 0.2$ small, $d = 0.5$ medium, $d = 0.8$ large. One-way ANOVA with partial eta-squared is reported for the partisan strength gradient analysis, which involves more than two ordered groups.

Stage 3: Exploratory Dimensionality Reduction. Principal Components Analysis (PCA) was conducted on the full battery of polarization items to identify dominant axes of variance and to provide a data-driven check on the theorized three-factor structure. PCA was chosen over

confirmatory factor analysis because the goal at this stage was exploratory visualization rather than latent variable estimation. Uniform Manifold Approximation and Projection (UMAP; McInnes, Healy, & Melville, 2018) was applied as a nonlinear complement, since it can recover cluster geometries that are not linearly separable. Both techniques serve as visualization tools only. A continuous or scattered distribution in PCA and UMAP output is the expected pattern for social science attitudinal data, indicating that students' political attitudes lie along a spectrum rather than dividing into discrete clusters, which is itself a substantive finding. Formal hypothesis tests rely on the methods in Stages 2 and 4.

Stage 4: Regression Analysis. Ordinary Least Squares (OLS) regression models were estimated with the free speech restriction index as the dependent variable, the three polarization components as independent variables, and party identification as a control. Regression was chosen over simple bivariate correlations for three reasons. First, it allows all three polarization components to be examined simultaneously, isolating each component's unique contribution while holding the others constant. Second, controlling for party allows the study to ask whether polarization predicts speech attitudes independent of partisan identity itself. Third, the inclusion of polarization-by-party interaction terms directly tests whether the polarization-speech relationship differs in magnitude or direction between Democrats and Republicans. A pooled model (M1), an interaction model (M2), and within-party models (M3-Dem and M3-Rep) were estimated in sequence.

Measures

Affective polarization was operationalized through three subscales measured on 1-5-point Likert scales, where higher values indicate greater polarization. Moral Identity (3 items per party direction) captures the extent to which respondents view their party as the morally correct side

and the opposition as morally deficient. Othering (3 items per party direction) captures the extent to which respondents view out-party members as categorically different from themselves. Social Aversion (6 items: Q135-Q140) measures behavioral unwillingness to associate with out-party members, including through friendship, family relationships, and social proximity. Items Q137 and Q140 were reverse-coded so that higher values are internally consistent. Aversion demonstrated acceptable internal consistency among Democrats ($\alpha = 0.82$) but lower consistency among Republicans ($\alpha = 0.65$). The slightly lower α among Republicans is consistent with greater attitudinal heterogeneity within that group rather than a measurement failure, and is itself a substantive finding about the crystallization of partisan attitudes.

Free speech attitudes were measured through two separate batteries on 1-7-point scales, where higher values indicate greater support for restriction. The faculty speech battery (Q92, Q95-Q102) asks whether faculty should face sanctions for expressing controversial views. The student speech battery (Q103-Q106) asks whether students should face academic consequences for controversial expression. Separating these batteries allows the study to test whether respondents apply consistent speech norms across groups or hold different standards for faculty versus students.

Party identification was coded on a 1-5 scale from Strong Democrat (1) to Strong Republican (5). Respondents who initially identified as not sure were asked a follow-up lean question. Those who leaned toward a party were assigned directional lean values, while persistent non-identifiers were coded as True Independents. This approach preserves the distinction between true independents and partisan leaners, who are theoretically important for understanding partisan strength gradients. For regression analyses, party was dichotomized as a binary variable (0 = Democrat, 1 = Republican).

Results

Overall Partisan Asymmetry in Affective Polarization

Consistent with H1, Democrats exhibit significantly higher overall affective polarization than Republicans. The combined index yields a mean of 2.89 (SD = 0.78) for Democrats versus 2.32 (SD = 0.62) for Republicans, $t(562) = -7.78$, $p < .001$, $d = 0.78$. The effect size of 0.78 represents a substantively meaningful gap, placing Democrats approximately three-quarters of a standard deviation above Republicans on the combined index. This replicates the asymmetric pattern documented by Orr and Huber (2020) and Finkel et al. (2020) in national adult samples and extends it to a college population in the Southeast, consistent with Nair et al.'s (2025) experimental evidence that Democrats dislike Republicans more across diverse behavioral operationalizations.

Table 2

Overall Affective Polarization by Party

Group	M	SD	t	df	p	d
Democrats	2.89	0.78				
Republicans	2.32	0.62				
Between-party			-7.78	562	< .001	0.78

Note. Independent-samples t-test, two-tailed. Scale: 1-5, higher = more polarized. $d = 0.78$ is a large effect by Cohen's (1988) benchmarks.

Figure 1

UMAP Projection of Affective Polarization Items by Party

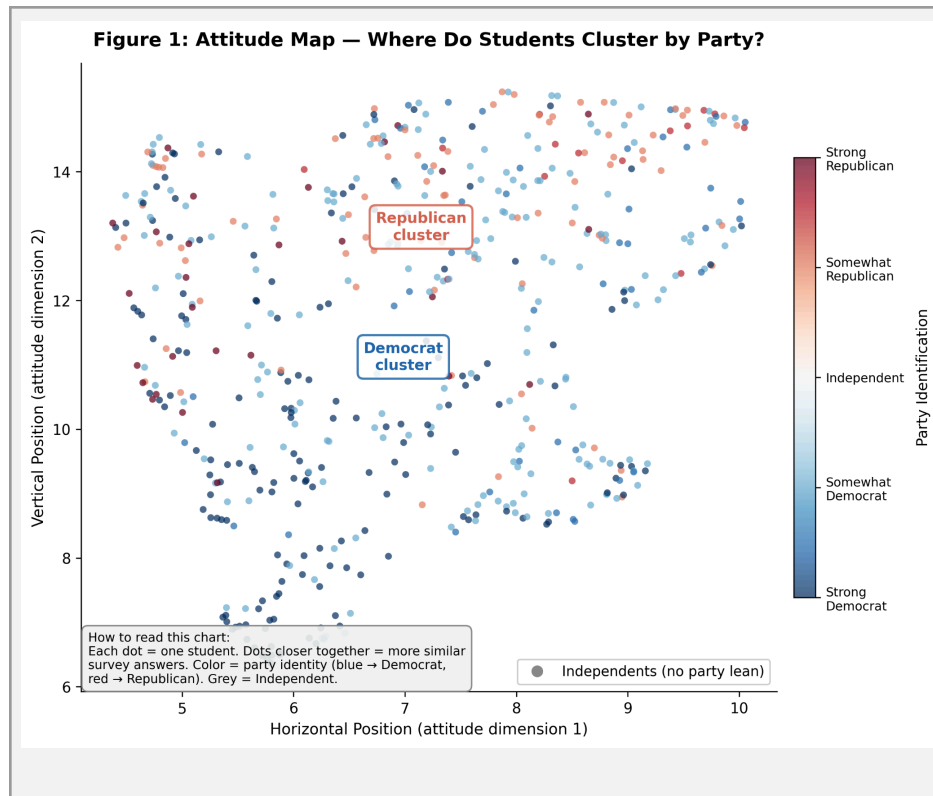
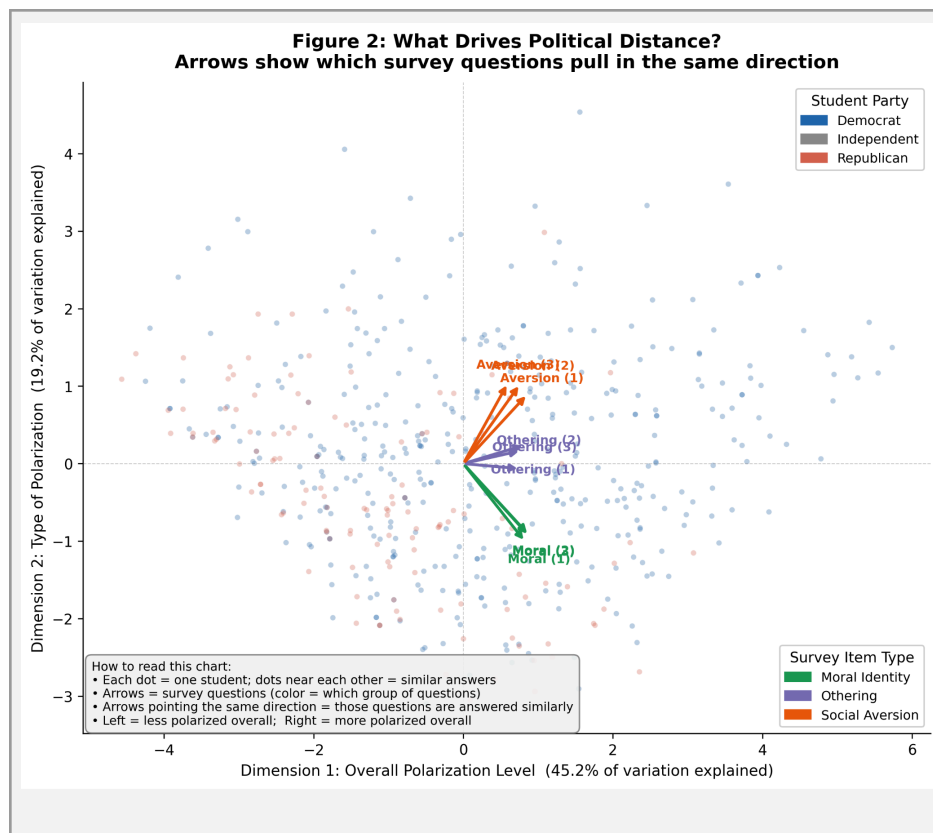


Figure 2

PCA Biplot of Affective Polarization Components



Three-Component Decomposition

Table 3 presents results for each component separately, supporting H2. Social aversion is qualitatively different from the other two components. The effect size of $d = .92$ exceeds the large benchmark by conventional standards, and the raw mean difference is nearly 0.9 points on a 5-point scale. Democrats report substantially greater unwillingness to befriend, date, or maintain close relationships with Republicans ($M = 2.32$), while Republicans' aversion toward Democrats is comparatively muted ($M = .63$). Moral identity ($d = 0.39$) and othering ($d = 0.41$), while statistically significant, represent small-to-moderate effects that are substantively much more modest. This pattern is consistent with Iyengar and Westwood's (2015) argument that partisan discrimination operates most powerfully in social rather than attitudinal domains, and

with Nair et al.'s (2025) finding that Democrats' moralized concern about harm to disadvantaged groups generates strong behavioral social distancing, precisely what the aversion subscale measures.

Table 3

Affective Polarization by Component and Party

Component	Democrats M (SD)	Republicans M (SD)	t	p	d
Moral Identity	3.37 (1.02)	2.96 (1.08)	-3.95	< .001	0.39
Othering	2.96 (0.97)	2.56 (0.93)	-4.12	< .001	0.41
Social Aversion (6 items)	2.32 (1.06)	1.42 (0.61)	-9.14	< .001	.92

Note. All tests two-tailed, independent samples. Scale: 1-5, higher = more polarized. Aversion items Q137 and Q140 reverse-coded.

Figure 3

Affective Polarization Index Distribution by Party

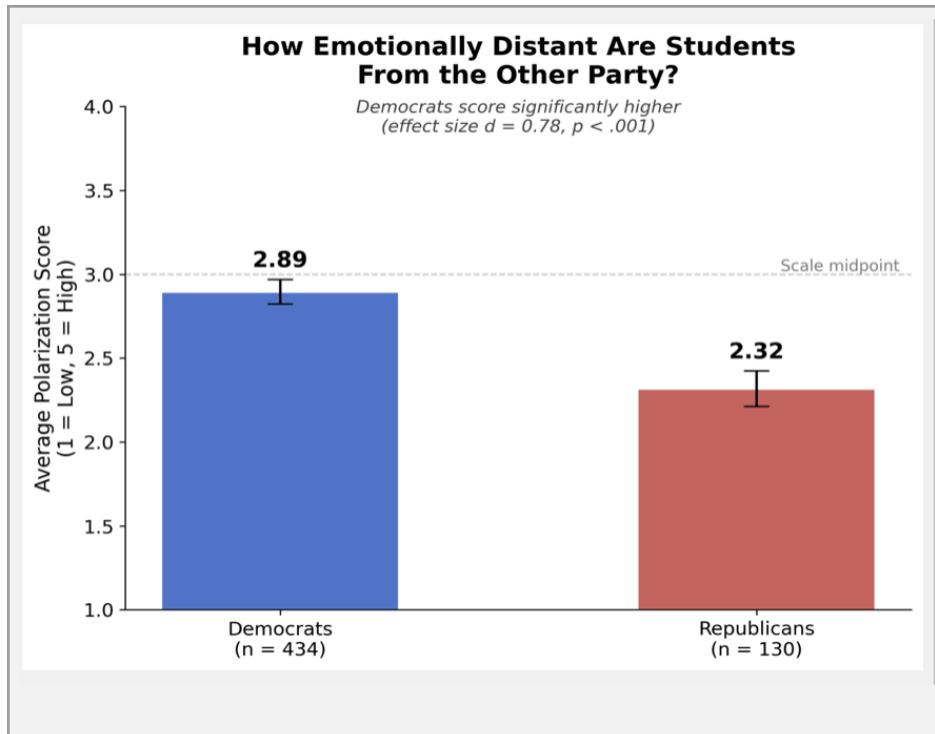
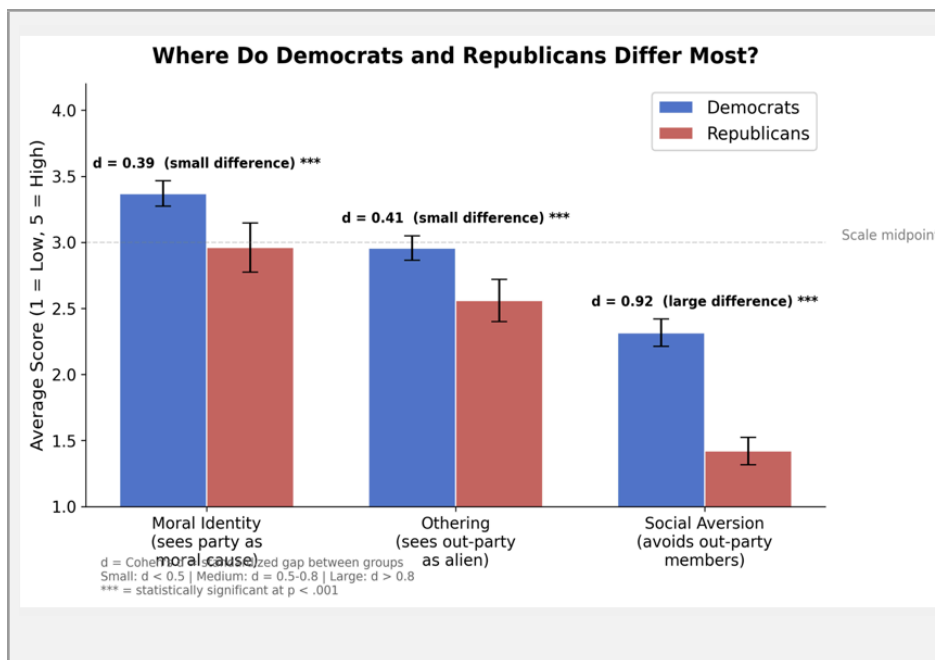


Figure 4

Component-Level Cohen's d Effect Sizes by Partisan Group

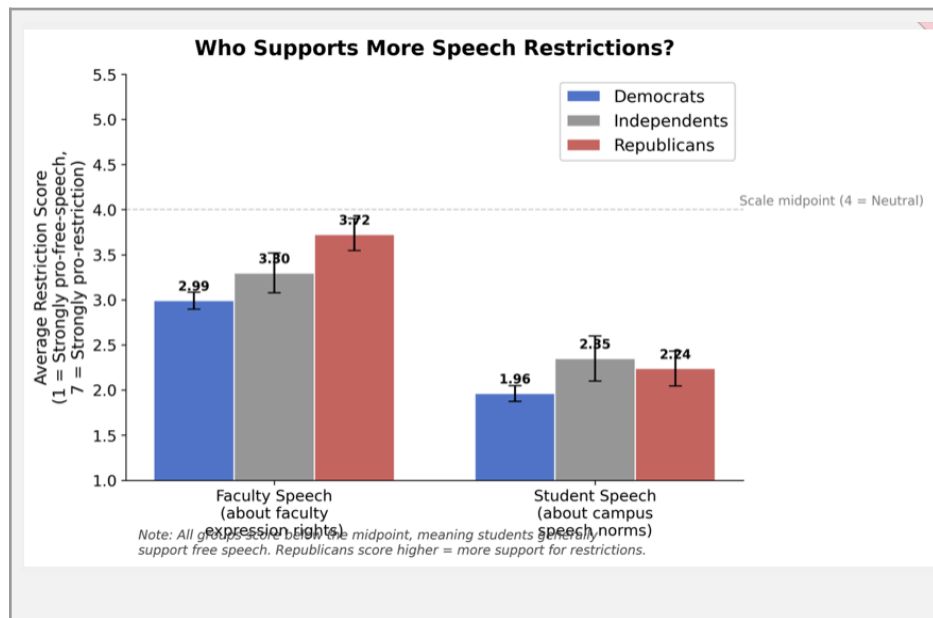


Free Speech Attitudes: Republicans More Restrictive

Consistent with H3, Republicans score significantly higher than Democrats on the combined speech restriction index, indicating greater support for restricting campus speech. Republicans' mean restriction score is 3.27 (SD = 0.88) versus Democrats' 2.67 (SD = 0.84), $t(542) = 6.93$, $p < .001$, $d = 0.69$. This moderate-to-large effect holds consistently across both faculty and student speech batteries and across all individual items in both scales, confirming the pattern is not driven by a subset of questions. True Independents fall between the two partisan groups, and partisan leaners track closely with their directional party, consistent with prior work showing that independent self-identification does not indicate genuinely centrist views (Levendusky, 2009).

Figure 5

Free Speech Restriction Scores by Party and Battery



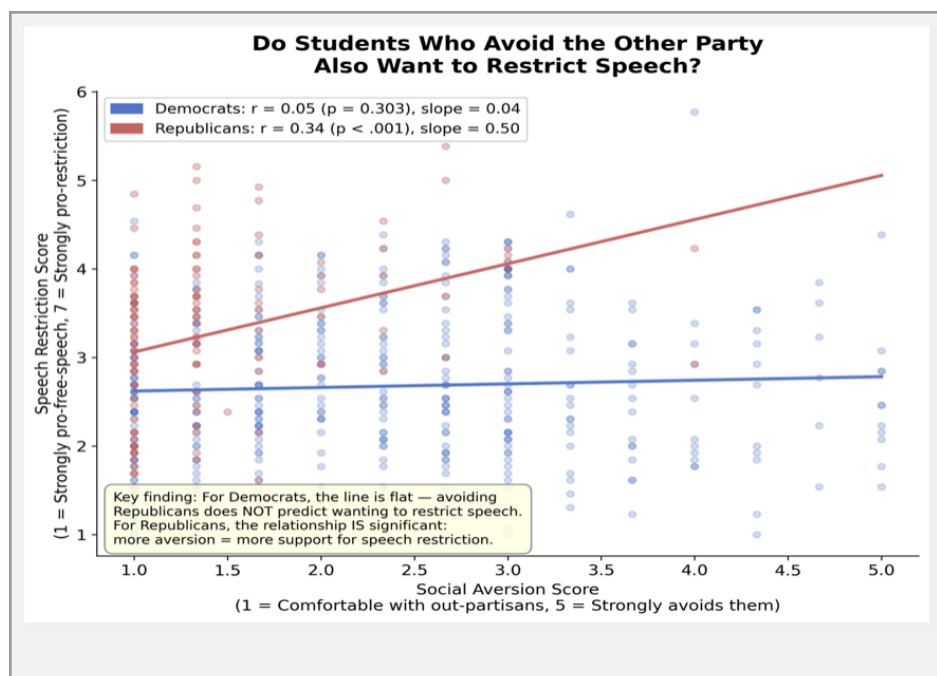
Note. Scale: 1-7, higher = greater support for restriction. Lower scores indicate stronger support for free speech.

The Polarization-Speech Paradox

The combination of findings from Tables 2 through 3 produces a polarization-speech paradox: the group that is more affectively polarized, Democrats, is simultaneously more supportive of free speech on campus. Within-party analyses reveal an asymmetric pattern. Among Democrats, Pearson correlations between all three polarization components and free speech restriction scores are near-zero and non-significant. Among Republicans, however, social aversion is a significant positive predictor of speech restriction support ($b = 0.49, p < .001$), indicating that more socially avoidant Republicans are also more supportive of speech restrictions. The paradox therefore applies specifically to Democrats: the most affectively polarized subgroup within the sample shows no individual-level link between their emotional hostility and their speech norms. This party-dependent structure is confirmed by the significant aversion-by-party interaction term ($b = 0.43, p = .001$) in the full interaction model.

Figure 6

Scatter Plot: Social Aversion vs. Speech Restriction by Party



Regression Analysis: Polarization Does Not Predict Speech Restriction

To test whether individual polarization levels predict speech restriction attitudes above and beyond partisan identity, OLS regression models were estimated with the combined speech restriction index as the dependent variable. In the pooled model (M1), all three polarization components and a party dummy were entered simultaneously. In the pooled model, moral identity was a significant negative predictor ($b = -0.13$, $p = .001$), meaning stronger moral identification with one's party predicted less support for speech restriction. Aversion was a marginally significant positive predictor ($b = 0.10$, $p = .02$). Othering was not significant ($b = 0.05$, $p = .28$). Party identification remained the strongest predictor ($b = 0.65$, $SE = 0.09$, $p < .001$). The full model explained approximately 11 percent of variance in speech restriction attitudes (R -squared = 0.11). However, the critical finding emerges in within-party models: among Republicans, social aversion was a strong and significant predictor of speech restriction support ($b = 0.49$, $SE = 0.12$, $p < .001$, R -squared = 0.12), while among Democrats, no

polarization component significantly predicted restriction attitudes (all $p > .05$, R-squared = 0.04). This asymmetry indicates that the relationship between polarization and speech attitudes is party-dependent.

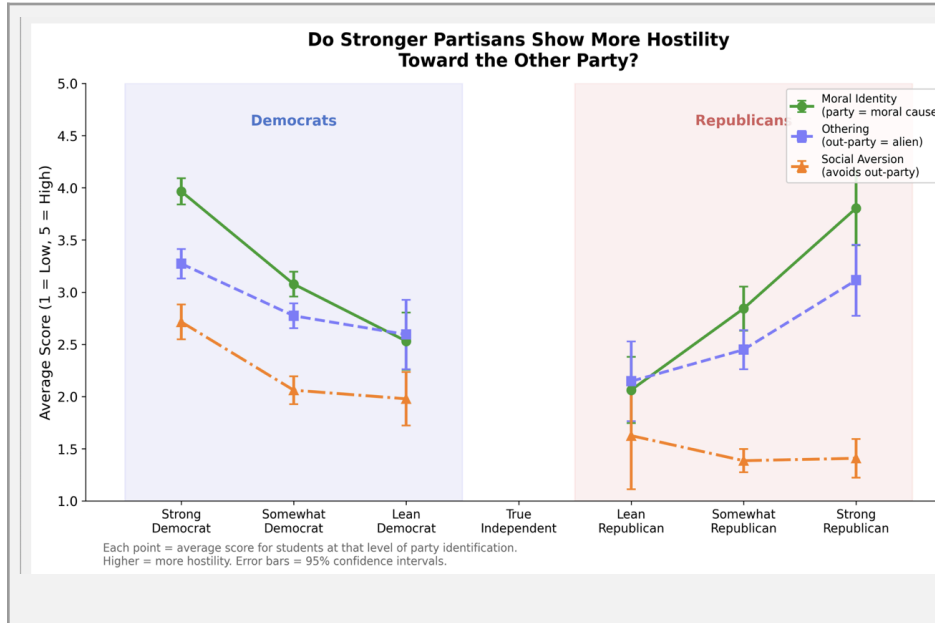
The interaction model (M2) added three polarization-by-party interaction terms to test whether the polarization-speech relationship differs between Democrats and Republicans. The aversion-by-party interaction was statistically significant ($b = 0.43$, $p = .001$), indicating that the relationship between social aversion and speech restriction attitudes differs meaningfully between the two parties. The moral identity-by-party interaction was also significant ($b = 0.18$, $p = .04$). Within-party models confirmed this pattern: among Republicans, social aversion was a strong predictor of speech restriction ($b = 0.49$, $p < .001$), while among Democrats no polarization component significantly predicted restriction attitudes. These results indicate that the polarization-speech relationship is party-dependent rather than universally absent: for Democrats, how polarized an individual is does not predict how restrictive their speech attitudes are, but for Republicans, social aversion is meaningfully linked to speech restrictiveness.

Partisan Strength Gradient

Affective polarization scales monotonically with partisan strength across the full gradient from Strong Democrat to Strong Republican. Strong Democrats score highest on all three components, with scores declining progressively through Somewhat Democrat, Lean Democrat, True Independent, Lean Republican, Somewhat Republican, and Strong Republican. The Democrat-above-Republican asymmetry is preserved at every strength level. This gradient finding reinforces the interpretation that the asymmetry is not an artifact of comparing strong Democrats to moderate Republicans, but rather a systematic feature of how Democratic and Republican identities are held in this population.

Figure 7

Partisan Strength Gradient: Affective Polarization by Party ID Strength



Discussion

This study contributes to the affective polarization literature in three distinct areas. First, it replicates and extends the asymmetric polarization finding in a college sample, demonstrating that Democrats being more polarized than Republicans is not confined to adult national samples. This replication is consistent with Orr and Huber (2020), Finkel et al. (2020), and Nair et al. (2025), who provide the most direct experimental evidence for the asymmetry and trace it to Democrats' moralized concern about harm to disadvantaged groups. Mason's (2018) prediction that social sorting amplifies affective polarization in university settings appears to hold: the effect size observed here ($d = 0.78$) is at the upper end of what national samples typically report.

Second, the three-component decomposition reveals that social aversion ($d = .92$) is the overwhelmingly dominant driver of the partisan gap in affective polarization, while moral identity ($d = 0.39$) and othering ($d = 0.41$) show substantively smaller differences. This disaggregation matters for practical interventions on campus. If the most extreme partisan divide is social rather than moral or epistemic, then programs emphasizing cross-party social contact may be more effective than those centered on perspective-taking or ideological dialogue. The Nair et al. (2025) framework further suggests that reducing Democrats' perception that Republicans pose harm to disadvantaged groups could address the underlying mechanism generating strong social aversion.

Third, and most consequentially, the OLS regression analysis establishes that the polarization-speech paradox holds at the individual level, not only between groups. Polarization components do not predict speech restriction attitudes among Democrats once party is controlled; however, among Republicans, social aversion significantly predicts support for speech restrictions ($b = 0.49$, $p < .001$), and the aversion-by-party interaction term is significant, indicating the polarization-speech relationship is party-dependent.

Several mechanisms could explain this paradox. Democrats in highly educated settings may hold strong commitments to First Amendment principles as ideological values that operate independently of their emotional reactions to Republicans, a pattern consistent with Gibson's (1992) finding that tolerance correlates with procedural democratic commitment. Alternatively, Democrats may express aversion toward Republicans as a social out-group while supporting abstract speech norms in a separate cognitive register, with the two attitudes activated in different contexts. A third possibility is that the speech batteries, which do not specify the political content or identity of the speaker, capture abstract support for free speech that would fracture if applied

to specifically partisan speech scenarios. This is consistent with Sullivan et al.'s (1982) tolerance gap framework, under which abstract and concrete tolerance routinely diverge.

As mentioned previously, the contextual timing of the Fall 2025 data collection period also warrants attention. The early months of the second Trump administration brought sustained federal pressure on universities around speech, diversity practices, and academic freedom. This context may have heightened the salience of free speech norms among Democrats, who were more likely to experience federal policy as a threat to institutional values, while simultaneously increasing Republicans' support for administrative speech enforcement in line with federal policy directions. Whether the paradox observed here is a stable feature of campus political psychology or a period-specific artifact of this political moment is an important question for longitudinal follow-up.

Limitations

Several limitations constrain the interpretation of these findings. The sample is drawn from a single institution and is not representative of the national undergraduate population. UNC Charlotte's particular demographic composition, including its racial diversity, predominantly commuter student body, and Southeastern location, may produce polarization patterns that differ from more selective or residential universities. Conclusions should be restricted to UNC Charlotte undergraduates and treated as a case study rather than generalized to all college students.

The sample imbalance, 437 Democrats versus 130 Republicans, limits statistical precision for Republican subgroups and means substantially more power exists to detect effects among Democrats. The cross-sectional design precludes causal inference. It is not possible to

determine from this dataset whether affective polarization drives speech restriction attitudes, whether common antecedents produce both, or whether the relationship is bidirectional. Longitudinal or experimental designs would be needed to establish causal direction.

Social desirability bias is a particular concern for aversion items. Respondents may underreport unwillingness to befriend out-party members because such attitudes carry social stigma in some campus environments. If so, the aversion scores reported here represent lower bounds on actual behavioral social distance. The lower Cronbach's alpha among Republicans ($\alpha = 0.65$) may reflect either measurement noise or genuine attitudinal heterogeneity, and may also reflect social desirability dynamics operating differently across partisan groups.

Finally, the free speech batteries measure abstract support for restricting speech without specifying the political content of the speech being evaluated. As Gibson and Gouws (2003) demonstrate, abstract and concrete speech norms can diverge substantially, and partisan groups may apply different standards to in-group versus out-group speech. The current measures cannot detect this conditional pattern, which represents an important direction for future research.

Conclusion

This study finds strong evidence of asymmetric affective polarization among UNC Charlotte undergraduates, with Democrats expressing significantly higher out-party hostility than Republicans across all three components of the Campos and Federico (2021) framework. The magnitude of the partisan gap in social aversion ($d = .92$) is particularly notable and is consistent with Nair et al.'s (2025) experimental evidence that Democrats' moralized concern about harm to disadvantaged groups generates strong behavioral social distancing from Republicans. The

partisan strength gradient confirms that this asymmetry is systematic across all levels of partisan identification and is not an artifact of differential distributions of strong versus weak identifiers.

The OLS regression analysis adds the central theoretical contribution: does not predict restriction attitudes among Democrats. The polarization-speech paradox, high emotional hostility toward political opponents coexisting with stronger support for their speech rights, suggests that affective polarization and democratic speech norms operate as independent dimensions in this population rather than as mutually reinforcing threats to campus climate. Between-party differences in speech attitudes reflect categorical partisan identity, not the degree of emotional polarization within either group.

For campus administrators and researchers concerned about both free expression and cross-partisan relationships among students, these findings suggest that the two concerns require distinct rather than unified responses. Reducing social aversion between partisan groups and protecting campus speech norms are both important goals, but the previous literature review and current data analyses indicate they are driven by different psychological and political processes. Specifically, categorical partisan identity for speech attitudes and moralized social distancing for affective polarization. Future research should examine whether this pattern holds across institutional contexts, whether experimental manipulations of partisan identity shift speech attitudes, and whether the relationship between polarization and speech norms changes when the speech being evaluated is explicitly partisan in content.

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Appendix

Table A1

Free Speech Restriction Attitudes by Party

Battery	Democrats M (SD)	Republicans M (SD)	t	p	d
Faculty Speech	2.99 (0.97)	3.72 (.92)	-7.37	< .001	0.74
Student Speech	1.96 (0.91)	2.24 (1.12)	-2.86	.004	0.29
Combined Index	2.67 (0.84)	3.27 (0.88)	-6.93	< .001	0.70

Figure A1

Does partisan hostility predict support for speech restrictions?

